

The e-mail

Clear purpose, proper format

WORD COUNT	REGISTER	SUBJECT LINE	SIGN-OFF
~250 words (225-275)	Formal (mostly at B2)	Required	Yours faithfully / sincerely

STRUCTURE AND LAYOUT

To: — [recipient's email]

From: — [your email]

Date: — [date]

Subject: — [clear and descriptive]

Dear Sir or Madam, / Dear Mr/Ms [Name],

Introduction — state why you are writing in the first sentence

Body paragraphs 1-3 — one bullet point per paragraph

Conclusion — restate purpose, expected response

Yours faithfully, / Yours sincerely, — faithfully = name unknown; sincerely = name known

DO'S AND DON'TS

DO

- Include all header elements (To, From, Date, Subject)
- State your reason for writing in the first sentence
- Use formal language — no slang
- Use full forms (do not instead of don't)
- Leave a blank line between paragraphs
- Match greeting to closing (Dear Sir → Yours faithfully)
- Use "softer" verbs when criticising: I would like to point out, it seems to me

DON'T

- No contractions in formal e-mails
- No emojis or emoticons
- No casual greetings (Hey, Hi there)
- Don't use an unprofessional e-mail address
- Don't forget a subject line
- Don't mix up faithfully/sincerely

WEAKER VS. STRONGER

WEAKER

STRONGER

"Hi! Your headphones broke after two days and I want my money back, thanks."

"Dear Sir or Madam, I am writing to request a refund for the headphones I bought on 3 May, which stopped working after two days."

Why it matters. A formal email names its purpose in the first line and keeps a polite, formal register throughout. The casual version would be marked down for register and tone.

KEY TIP

Key tip. Faithfully vs. sincerely: "Dear Sir/Madam" (name unknown) → Yours faithfully. "Dear Mr/Ms Brown" (name known) → Yours sincerely. Getting this wrong is an instant flag for examiners.

USEFUL PHRASES

Complaint openers

- I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with...
- I am writing to complain about...
- I would like to draw your attention to...
- I was appalled to find...

Application openers

- I am writing to apply for the position of... as advertised in...
- I am writing with reference to your advertisement...
- I believe I am suitable for the position as I...

Letter to the editor openers

- I am writing in response to the article on..., which appeared in... on [date].
- I have just read your article on... and I feel I must respond.
- You raised some issues which I feel strongly about.

Closings (all sub-types)

- I look forward to hearing from you at your earliest convenience.
- I look forward to receiving the information requested.
- I am available for an interview at your convenience.
- Thank you for your cooperation in correcting this matter.

MODEL TEXT

Complaint regarding Summer Language Course in Brighton (~250 words · Formal)

To: info@globalenglish.example From: sarah.berger@email.example Date: 10 April 2026 Subject: Complaint regarding Summer Language Course in Brighton

Dear Sir or Madam, I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with the two-week language course I attended at your Brighton school from 1 to 14 July 2025. Although your website promised small class sizes and experienced teachers, my experience was far from what had been advertised. I had specifically chosen your school because of these promises, so the reality on arrival was a

serious disappointment.

To begin with, the classes had up to 22 students, which made individual attention impossible. Furthermore, our teacher changed three times during the course, and the final replacement had no formal teaching qualification. As a result, several students felt they had not improved at all. On top of this, the afternoon activities advertised in the brochure were cancelled twice without notice. When I raised these problems with the reception staff, I was simply told that nothing could be done, and none of the staff seemed willing to take responsibility.

I would therefore like to request a partial refund of the course fees, as the services provided did not match the description on your website. I look forward to hearing from you within 14 days. Should I not receive a satisfactory response, I will have no choice but to share my experience on public review platforms. Yours faithfully, Sarah Berger

More online. This text type also has a second model text on a different topic for you to analyse yourself, plus quizzes and a sentence-ordering exercise, at matura.bernhardgmeiner.com.